Swimmer Archie Goodburn Helps Win New Support for Brain Cancer Patients

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Scottish swimmer Archie Goodburn has helped convince the United Kingdom's government to take new steps to improve care for people with brain cancer.

Goodburn, who is 25, was **diagnosed** two years ago with three brain **tumors** that doctors cannot remove with surgery. He went for medical tests after having health problems while training for the 2024 Olympic trials. He has been treated with medicines and **radiation therapy**. Even so, he kept racing and reached the final of the 50-meter **breaststroke** at the 2026 Commonwealth Games in Glasgow.

After Goodburn made an emotional appeal on TV for more money for brain cancer research, Prime Minister Andy Burnham invited him to Downing Street, where the prime minister works. After their meeting, Burnham announced several plans.

The government will name a national leader for brain cancer care. It will also review how much progress has been made on brain cancer since 2018 and what is still holding progress back. The review will be led by Professor Anthony Chalmers of the University of Glasgow. After that, a national plan aims to get new treatments "out of the lab and to patients faster," the government said.

Burnham also asked the agency that oversees medicines to finish reviewing its rules for treatments for rare conditions in two years instead of three. Patients, families and charities will help design a push to get more people into **clinical trials**, which test new treatments.

Goodburn thanked the prime minister. He said all three of his requests had been "promised to some extent," but that the details still need work.

Burnham called Goodburn "an inspiration to us all." He said, "Families facing this disease can't afford to wait."

Word Treasure

tumors -- Tumors are lumps of cells that grow in the body when they should not.

diagnosed -- Diagnosed means a doctor has found out what illness a person has.

breaststroke -- Breaststroke is a swimming style where the arms push forward and sweep out while the legs kick like a frog.

radiation therapy -- Radiation therapy is a treatment that uses strong energy beams to attack cancer cells.

clinical trials -- Clinical trials are careful tests that check whether new medical treatments are safe and work.

Background you need

The Commonwealth Games are a large sports competition, held every few years, for athletes from countries that were once part of the British Empire.

Brain cancer is hard to treat because the brain is delicate, so doctors cannot always remove tumors with surgery.

In the United Kingdom, the prime minister leads the government and works at Downing Street in London.

New medicines must be tested in clinical trials and approved by regulators before most patients can use them, which can take years.

Break it down

LEAD: Swimmer Archie Goodburn helps win new UK government steps on brain cancer care.
BACKGROUND: Goodburn, 25, has brain tumors that cannot be removed by surgery but still reached a Commonwealth Games final
KEY EVENT: Meeting with Prime Minister Andy Burnham after an emotional TV appeal
+- PLAN 1: A national leader for brain cancer care
+- PLAN 2: A review of progress since 2018, led by Professor Anthony Chalmers
+- PLAN 3: Faster medicine-rule review and more people in clinical trials
REACTION: Goodburn says his requests were "promised to some extent"; Burnham calls him "an inspiration"
OPEN QUESTION: The details of the plans still need to be worked out.

Why it matters

One athlete's public appeal led to government action that could help brain cancer patients get new treatments sooner.

Test what you remember

1. How old is Archie Goodburn?

(A) 25
(B) 30
(C) 18
(D) 50

2. Which race did Goodburn reach the final of at the 2026 Commonwealth Games?

(A) 200-meter butterfly
(B) 50-meter breaststroke
(C) 100-meter freestyle
(D) Marathon swim

3. Who invited Goodburn to Downing Street?

(A) A TV host
(B) The King
(C) Prime Minister Andy Burnham
(D) Professor Anthony Chalmers

4. Who will lead the review of brain cancer progress?

(A) Professor Anthony Chalmers of the University of Glasgow
(B) A swimming coach
(C) Andy Burnham
(D) Archie Goodburn

5. What did Burnham ask the medicines agency to do?

(A) Make swimming pools free
(B) Close down
(C) Stop all clinical trials
(D) Finish reviewing rules for rare-condition treatments in two years instead of three

6. How did Goodburn describe the response to his three requests?

(A) "Completely refused"
(B) "Already finished"
(C) "Too late"
(D) "Promised to some extent"

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: A 2: B 3: C 4: A 5: D 6: D

Questions to think about

1. Archie Goodburn: He thanked the prime minister and said his requests were promised to some extent, but the details still need work.

2. Prime Minister Andy Burnham: He said progress on brain cancer has not been good enough and families facing the disease can't afford to wait.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):